SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #15 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“People in my town will always see me as I was.”

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Where it often comes from

In small towns and tight communities, people remember. A teenage mistake, a divorce, an addiction, or a family scandal may be recalled for decades. Even after real change, we may feel watched for relapse and seen through an old lens.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “From now on we regard no one according to the flesh… Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” The Lord says, “Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new.” After his conversion, Saul was feared by the church, but Barnabas stood with him. God is not limited by what people remember. While some will take time to see change, others will welcome it, and our task is to live faithfully and be patient.

> *“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Also see

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus” (Acts 9:26–27).

> “He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out” (Proverbs 10:9).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- They will never forget what I did.
- I will always be that person to them.
- No matter how I change, they will not see it.
- I cannot outlive my past here.
- Every look reminds me.
- People never change their minds about me.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what everyone remembers and thinks.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that no one will change their view.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating all townspeople as one mind.
- Labeling: Letting an old label stand for who I am now.

Challenging questions

- Who in my town has already responded to my change with kindness?
- What do I want to be known for in five years?
- What can I do consistently to show the change?
- Whose opinion do I weigh most, and why?
- What does God see when He looks at me now?
- Do I need a fresh start somewhere else, or can I stay with patience?

Truth summary

> God sees me as a new creation, and He is not limited by what others recall. Some people may take time to see my change. I can live faithfully, be patient, and look for those who welcome the new.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Born Again
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Humility
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "People in my town will always see me as I was"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People in my town will always see me as I was." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who has responded kindly?
- ☐ What do I want to be known for?
- ☐ What can I do consistently?
- ☐ Whose opinion matters?
- ☐ What does God see?
- ☐ Do I need support?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am a new creation.
- ☐ God does not call to mind the former things.
- ☐ Consistency builds a new story.
- ☐ Barnabas-type friends exist.
- ☐ Some will see the change in time.
- ☐ My identity is not their memory.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Isaiah 43:18–19
  "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'"
- ☐ Acts 9:26–27
  "When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ The new story: Each week, note one thing consistent with who you are now.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 5:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The old has passed away, and the new has come.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Born Again" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Tell the new story. Write who you are now in three sentences.
- ☐ Be consistent. Choose small, reliable actions.
- ☐ Find allies. Seek out those who encourage you.
- ☐ Release the old. Practice letting go of the need to be fully understood.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People in my town will always see me as I was": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	The new story
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People in my town will always see me as I was.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You make all things new. Free me from living under others' memory, help me live faithfully, and give me patience while people see the change. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.